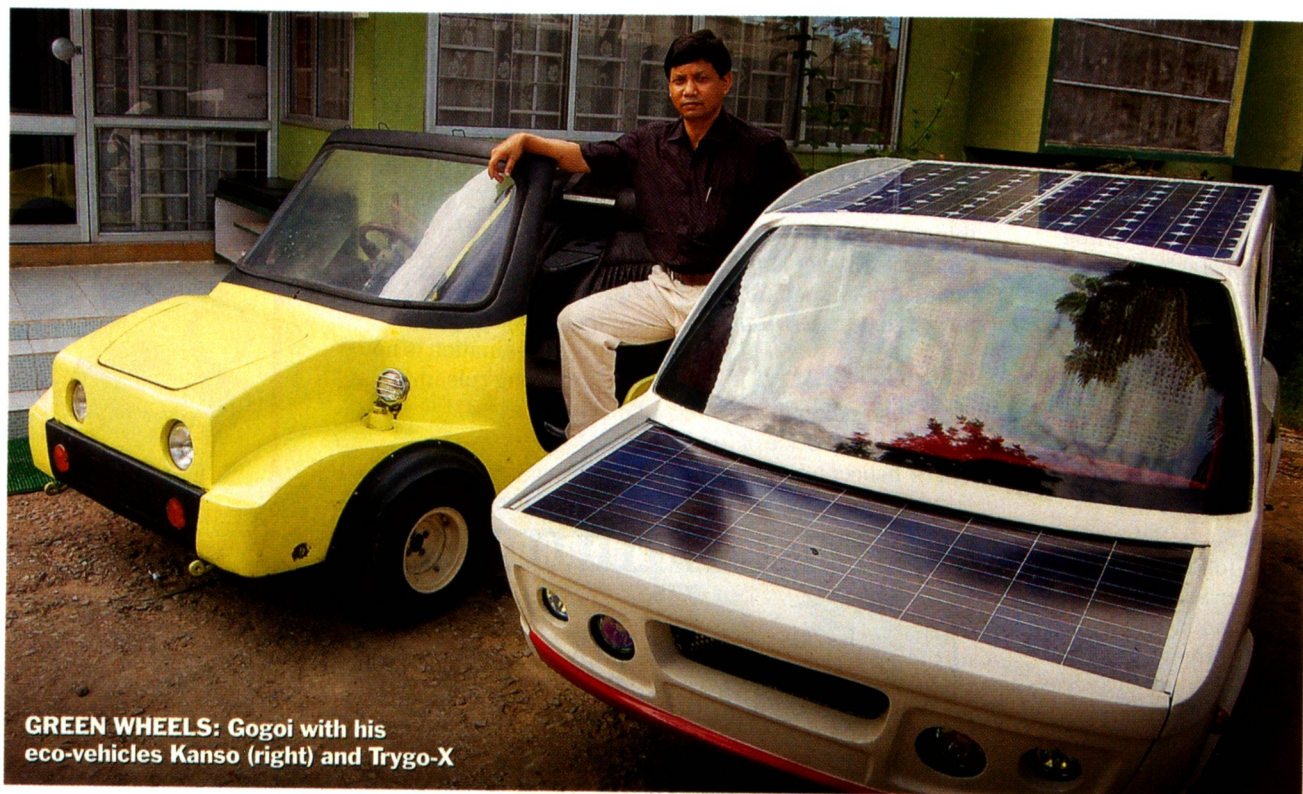




GREEN WHEELS: Gogoi with his eco-vehicles Kanso (right) and Trygo-X

A Drive in the Sun

A compulsive innovator adds to his range of quirky and alternative transport by developing a hybrid car

■ By Nandini Vaish

While every Indian carmaker is joining the global race to make a green vehicle, there is a quiet innovation taking place in a nondescript house in Guwahati, Assam.

Kanak Gogoi, 47, a contractor by profession, has developed a small prototype by the name of Kanso, a solar-gas hybrid car that runs on solar cells—basically on solar energy. The 100-cc, two-seater vehicle weighs 350 kg, goes up to a maximum speed of 40 km/h and can travel around 70 km on battery as well as petrol. Kanso doesn't have gears and its solar panels can generate up to 320 watts of power as was displayed at the Guwahati Auto Fair in February. The manufacturing cost of the car is Rs 1.50 lakh.

A compulsive innovator, Gogoi has always been fond of experimenting with electronics. In 1996, he set up a small garage at his home in Mathura Nagar in the state capital. Since then he has developed a number of vehicles—a motorcycle, a three-wheeler called the Trygo-X and a ramp that can generate electricity from the traffic on the road. In 2001, he developed a hand-glider that was powered by a two-stroke motorbike engine.

In 2002, it was an aero-boat that was propelled using an aero-propeller and in 2003, he designed the Amphibian Boat, which can sail on water and move on land. This took



Gogoi nearly two months and cost Rs 25,000 to make. His innovations are particularly interesting given that he has no background in the auto or energy industries.

His latest obsession with the hybrid car began in July 2007, when he attended a conference in Chicago. On a visit to the Museum of Science and Industry—which was hosting the American Solar Challenge—he saw a variety of solar cars and asked himself: "Why can't I develop a car like this?" Within the next three months, this political science student spent his time reading on electric vehicles. Once he had his design, it was just a matter of getting the parts and assembling them. "The car was built through the imagination," says Gogoi.

Ironically, he still drives around in a Maruti 800. He can't legally drive Kanso as it does not have a clearance from the road transport office. He has tried, he says, "but the process is just too long and complicated".

But his efforts have not been wasted entirely. The Centre for Bits and Atom at Massachusetts Institute of Technology's Media Lab, which funds research and development, has extended financial assistance to Gogoi to set up a new digital lab for more innovations. Gogoi has brought a fresh new perspective to clean vehicles. The challenge will now be to find an investor who can commercialise them. As of now, Gogoi is content with driving them around in his locality. ■